

# Delaware County Budget Hearings September 7th 2023

## Segment #1

| Meeting Metadata | Details                                                                                               |
|------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Video Recording  | <a href="https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=rAiTjmouZXU">https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=rAiTjmouZXU</a> |
| Publication Date | 2023-09-07T17:51:49Z                                                                                  |
| Target Category  | delaware_county                                                                                       |

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## Comprehensive Municipal Meeting Analysis & Report

### 1. Pre-Meeting Hearings & Committee Work Sessions

(No statutory public hearing or committee session was held immediately prior to calling the regular meeting to order; this session is a direct physical continuation/recess of a multi-day budget work session.)

### 2. Meeting Identification & Attendance

- **Call to Order & Spoken Details:** Presiding officer noted the meeting resumed from recess at [00:12:39](#), explicitly confirming it as a physical continuation of the ongoing Council budget review sessions.
- **Attendance:**
  - **Members Present:** The entire Council is present (explicitly stated at [00:12:44](#)). Key council members actively participating by name or voice include Ryan, Bill, Jim, and Dan, alongside staff members including Tanya (Auditor/Finance staff) and Matt.
  - **Members Absent:** None.
  - **Presiding Officer:** Led by the Council President.

### 3. Preliminary & Procedural Business

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- **Ceremonial Openings:** Mentioned that prior sessions opened with the Pledge of Allegiance, though the current block is a direct continuation of ongoing work.
  - **Approval of Minutes:** None addressed during this budget work session block.
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### 4. Substantive Business & Board Action

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*(The following budget reviews, departmental funding adjustments, and line-item negotiations occurred sequentially in chronological order.)*

- **00:12:39 Budget Work Session: Information Technology / Computer Department**
  - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Jim (IT / Department Head).
  - **Deliberation Summary:** The Council reviewed line-by-line operating expenses, software maintenance contracts, contractual services (Line 311 at \$204,000), and hardware maintenance (Line 361). Extensive debate focused on whether 10% software maintenance escalation increases were contractually mandated or anticipated, and whether vendors could offer relief. Wish-list items such as network management tools (Line 364) and computer equipment upgrades (Line 441) were reduced or zeroed out to match 2023 baseline spending levels where applicable.
  - **Item-Specific Public Input:** None.
  - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Consensus adjustments reached via board discussion; finalized line targets adjusted downward toward 2023 baseline levels.
- **00:29:15 Budget Work Session: Purdue Extension Office**
  - **Sponsor / Presenter:** County Extension Director.
  - **Deliberation Summary:** Reviewed contractual services with Purdue University (reflecting a mandatory statewide 4% increase). The Director and Council discussed the community value of Extension programming (4-H, self-sufficiency, food security) versus tightening county financial constraints. The Director agreed to review current-year line balances to return unspent funds due to prior-year staffing vacancies.
  - **Item-Specific Public Input:** Director testified regarding long-term cost prevention benefits of youth and community programming.
  - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Consensus to hold contractual line near requested adjustments while directing the department head to review and identify potential 2023 give-backs.
- **00:41:53 Budget Work Session: Clerk / Financial Administration**
  - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Brad (Department Head).
  - **Deliberation Summary:** Detailed line items including bank fees (Line 312), office supplies, equipment repairs (money counter replacement), schooling, and staff salaries. Debate ensued over whether bank fee projections could be compressed

from \$12,500 down to \$10,000 based on historical balances, despite potential unknown rate fluctuations. Brad confirmed ability to return \$5,000 from current-year 2023 line balances.

- **Item-Specific Public Input:** Brad (Department Head) provided operational testimony regarding bank fee unpredictability and local banking arrangements.
- **Action & Vote Disposition:** Consensus adjustments made to equipment and supply lines, with bank fees targeted at \$10,000 pending final verification.
- **01:13:22 Budget Work Session: Surveyor's Office & Drainage Board**
  - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Tommy (County Surveyor).
  - **Deliberation Summary:** Reviewed baseline salary lines and statutory Drainage Board per-diem board compensation (\$1,500/year). A council member proposed eliminating or reducing paid board positions to \$1,000 to signal fiscal restraint. Other members and legal counsel strongly defended the board's broad statutory authority under the drainage code and noted per-diems had remained unchanged for over 20 years.
  - **Item-Specific Public Input:** None from the general public during this segment.
  - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Consensus reached to maintain Drainage Board compensation at 2023 levels (rejecting the proposed reduction).
- **01:29:20 Budget Work Session: Assessor's Office**
  - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Tim Carmichael (Assessor) / Paula Morrison (Chief Deputy).
  - **Deliberation Summary:** Reviewed operating funds, postage increases, and a specific personnel request to reclassify an "Office Manager" title to "Chief Deputy" to align with comparable offices (like the Treasurer) and correct a prior-year salary omission.
  - **Item-Specific Public Input:**
    - **01:46:13 Paula Morrison** (Chief Deputy County Assessor) spoke at the podium, testifying regarding historical title structures, multi-faceted duties, and longevity integration.
  - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Consensus held on maintaining baseline 2023 title/salary structures pending potential internal budget trade-offs by the department head.
- **01:59:06 Budget Work Session: Recorder's Office & Perpetuation Fund**
  - **Sponsor / Presenter:** County Recorder.
  - **Deliberation Summary:** Reviewed general fund budgets and the Recorder's Perpetuation Fund (Fund 77). Discussed upcoming statutory compliance mandates (such as "Daniel's Law" concerning redaction of sensitive personal/public safety data) and document preservation projects backed by robust fund cash balances exceeding \$1.1 million.
  - **Item-Specific Public Input:** None.
  - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved by consensus to maintain perpetuation fund line allocations with structural adjustments to salary and benefit lines.

- **02:12:38 Budget Work Session: Metropolitan Planning Organization (MPO) / Planning**
  - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Crystal.
  - **Deliberation Summary:** Reviewed federal reimbursement structures (noting ~66% to 80% federal match on specific planning salaries) and interlocal funding discussions involving the city. Debated proposals for new full-time staffing additions versus retaining flexible part-time hourly capabilities.
  - **Item-Specific Public Input:** Crystal presented data on revenue generation, permit fees, and federal work-program reimbursements.
  - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Consensus to defer new full-time position creation and retain part-time allocations pending ongoing revenue updates.
- **02:22:38 Budget Work Session: Coroner's Office**
  - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Gavin (Coroner) / Adam & Gary (Chief Deputy / Investigators).
  - **Deliberation Summary:** Reviewed operating costs, 24/7 on-call burdens, cell phone/pager expenses, and a proposed reclassification/salary adjustment for the Administrative Assistant / Lead Investigator role. Debated the equity of the proposed 15%+ pay increase relative to other administrative roles countywide, balanced against significant reductions in part-time weekend call usage achieved by the department.
  - **Item-Specific Public Input:**
    - **02:37:06 Adam / Office Staff** provided testimony regarding expanded investigator duties, 24/7 scene response, and family notification burdens.
  - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Consensus reached to accept the department's overall budget structure which achieved a net spending decrease of over \$11,000 compared to 2023 baselines.
- **03:05:43 Budget Work Session: Prosecutor's Office**
  - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Eric (Prosecutor) / Lisa.
  - **Deliberation Summary:** Reviewed major litigation lines (transcription/trial expenses, witness fees), advertising for open attorney positions, and staff retention stipends originally appropriated in March. The Prosecutor noted the office is currently short two deputy prosecutors and facing an upcoming murder trial. Discussion focused on balancing trial-expense line items against unpredictable crime rates, with the Prosecutor committing not to transfer unspent litigation funds to other administrative lines.
  - **Item-Specific Public Input:** Prosecutor Eric provided extensive testimony on public safety demands, retention challenges, and trial-cost volatility.
  - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Consensus adjustments applied to trial/witness lines and position allocations, balancing requested expansions against countywide revenue constraints.
- **04:14:49 Budget Work Session: Tourism / Convention & Visitors Bureau**
  - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Council Members.

- **Deliberation Summary:** Briefly reviewed Fund 1127 (Innkeeper's Tax / Tourism). Raised institutional concerns regarding executive salary growth within contracted 501(c)(6) non-profit tourism entities ("Visit Muncie Inc.") and the lack of direct fiscal body oversight since council representation was removed from the tourism board by the Commissioners.
  - **Item-Specific Public Input:** None.
  - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Consensus directed administrative staff to draft a formal letter to the Board of Commissioners requesting the restoration of a fiscal body (Council) representative on the tourism board.
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## 5. Open Public Comment / Citizen Forum

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*(No general citizen forum or open floor public comment period for non-agenda items occurred during this working budget session; public remarks were strictly confined to departmental budget presentations detailed in Section 4).*

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## 6. Administrative Updates & Adjournment

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- **Staff / Board Announcements:**
    - The Council noted the cumulative financial impact of ongoing budget adjustments and scheduled an afternoon recess.
    - Administrative staff tasked with drafting correspondence to the Commissioners regarding tourism board representation.
  - **Adjournment:**
    - Official action: Presiding officer recessed the meeting for lunch with instructions to reconvene at 2:00 PM (04:19:54).
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